

October Skies Bring Hidden Jupiter and Meteor Showers

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October nights offer several sky shows. On October 6, people in parts of North America could see Jupiter hide behind the Moon for about an hour. That is called a lunar **occultation**.

The **Draconid meteor shower** peaked on October 8 and 9. These shooting stars can be seen after nightfall, around 9 p.m. Eastern. They usually come only a few each hour. Dark skies near new Moon helped.

The **Orionids** peak around October 21. They come from bits of **Halley's Comet**. Suburban viewers may see about 3 to 6 meteors an hour. A bright Moon may hide faint ones until it sets near 3 a.m.

You do not need a telescope just a clear, dark place and time to look up.

Word Treasure

occultation -- When one sky object hides another for a while.

meteor shower -- A time when many shooting stars appear.

Draconid -- An October meteor shower named for a dragon constellation.

Orionids -- A meteor shower made from bits of Halley's Comet.

Halley's Comet -- A famous comet whose leftover bits make Orionid meteors.

Background you need

Meteor showers happen when Earth passes through dusty trails left by comets.
The Moon can hide a planet for a short time when it lines up just right.
Darker skies make faint shooting stars easier to see.

Break it down

WHO: Skywatchers in North America and elsewhere

WHAT: Jupiter occultation and two meteor showers

WHERE: The night sky in October

WHY: Seasonal astronomy events kids can watch outdoors

Why it matters

Knowing when meteors peak helps families plan a fun night of real skywatching.

Test what you remember

1. What is a lunar occultation in this story?

- ☐ (A) A bike test
- ☐ (B) A dog MRI
- ☐ (C) A podcast prize
- ☐ (D) Jupiter hiding behind the Moon

2. When did the Draconids peak?

- ☐ (A) July 4
- ☐ (B) December 25
- ☐ (C) October 8 and 9
- ☐ (D) Only at noon

3. Where do Orionid meteors come from?

- ☐ (A) Bits of Halley's Comet
- ☐ (B) Airplane lights
- ☐ (C) Bike lights
- ☐ (D) Phone flashes

4. About how many Orionids might suburban viewers see each hour?

- ☐ (A) One thousand
- ☐ (B) About 3 to 6
- ☐ (C) Zero always
- ☐ (D) Exactly 100

5. Do you need a telescope for these shows?

- ☐ (A) Yes, always
- ☐ (B) No
- ☐ (C) Only a helmet
- ☐ (D) Only a spacesuit

6. When can Draconids be watched?

- ☐ (A) Only at sunrise from Mars
- ☐ (B) Only underwater
- ☐ (C) Only in classrooms
- ☐ (D) Soon after nightfall

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: A 4: B 5: B 6: D

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):